SARNISH KOUR

Squadron Leader (Retd.) · PhD Candidate (Management — Entrepreneurship)
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RESEARCH STATEMENT

My research lies at the intersection of entrepreneurial cognition and opportunity development, with a central focus on perspective-taking: the capacity to understand the thoughts, feelings, and motivations of others. I examine how this other-oriented cognition shapes the ways in which entrepreneurs recognise, develop, and act upon opportunities, and how it operates within entrepreneurial teams, where empathic understanding among cofounders bears upon venture performance. Alongside its benefits, I am interested in the boundary conditions and darker side of perspective-taking, including when attending to others' perspectives may distort judgement or be deployed instrumentally. An emerging line of inquiry examines how impact investors evaluate and make decisions about social ventures. My work is grounded in sustained engagement with practising entrepreneurs, combining systematic review with in-depth qualitative fieldwork; my doctoral research applies these ideas to social entrepreneurship, developing a process model of how founders arrive at impact opportunities. Informed by more than seventeen years of practice across defence, global consulting, and higher education, I seek to produce scholarship that matters beyond the academy: for entrepreneurs creating value, for educators cultivating entrepreneurial mindsets, and for policymakers building ecosystems that enable impact.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Entrepreneurial Cognition · Opportunity Recognition & Development · Perspective-Taking & Empathy in Entrepreneurship · The Dark Side of Perspective-Taking · Entrepreneurial Teams · Social Entrepreneurship & Impact Investing

EDUCATION

PhD (Pursuing) – Management (Entrepreneurship) | LM Thapar School of Management, TIET

Thesis: Role of Perspective-taking in Impact Opportunity Development: An Exploration of the Processual View of Social Entrepreneurship | Supervisors: Dr. Raja Singaram & Prof. Padmakumar Nair | CGPA: 9.63 / 10 | Registered October 2020 | AACSB-accredited school

Residential Course in Business Management (6 months) | IIM Indore

MBA (HR) | IGNOU

MS (Software Systems) — M.Tech. equivalent | BITS Pilani (Work Integrated Learning Programme)

PG Diploma in Aeronautical Engineering | AFTC, Bangalore & VTU, Belgaum

B.E. (Information Technology) | MBS College of Engineering, Jammu University

ACADEMIC DISTINCTIONS

- University rank holder, B.E. (IT), Jammu University: 9th position (Semester I) and 7th position (Semester II)
- Matriculation, J&K State Board of School Education: 1st in school, 1st in district, 5th in state; awarded full scholarship for higher secondary education
- National Children's Science Congress 2000: presented project "Saving of Electricity" at Bengal Engineering College, Shibpur (selected by J&K State Council for Science & Technology)
- CSIR Programme on Youth for Leadership in Science, Regional Research Laboratory, Jammu (2000); multiple first prizes in debates and symposia (Directorate of Field Publicity, Ministry of I&B, 1996–1998) and district-level science quizzes

PUBLICATIONS & CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

(I) Conference Papers & Doctoral Consortiums

- Singaram, R., & Kour, S. (2023). The Role of Perspective-Taking in Social Venture Opportunity Development. *Academy of Management Proceedings, Vol. 2023, No. 1, p. 10022. Briarcliff Manor, NY: Academy of Management.* ★ **Best Paper Proceedings**

- Kour, S., Singaram, R., Gartner, W.B., & Nair, P. (2024). Impact Opportunity Development: A Process View — Trajectory-based process model. *Social Entrepreneurship Conference 2024, IMD Lausanne, Switzerland.*
- USASBE Doctoral Consortium 2024
- Doctoral Consortium — ENT Division, 85th Annual AOM Conference, 2025, Copenhagen, Denmark

(II) Co-authored Contributions

- Hari, S., Singaram, R., & Kour, S. (2024). Understanding the Role of Empathy in Entrepreneurship: A Review and Future Directions. *Annual Academy of Management Conference, Chicago, Illinois, USA.*
- Hari, S., Singaram, R., Kour, S., & Gartner, W.B. (2025). Perceived Heavens And Imagined Hells: Empathic Understanding Among Cofounder Dyads And Its Effect On Team Performance. *Babson College Entrepreneurship Research Conference, Wellesley, Massachusetts, USA.*
- Hari, S., Singaram, R., Kour, S., & Gartner, W.B. (2025). The Role of Empathic Understanding in Cofounder Relationships. *85th Annual Academy of Management Conference, Copenhagen, Denmark.*

(III) Early Presentations (Undergraduate)

- Kour, S. (2007). People's Participation in Conservation of Water Resources and Preservation of Its Quality: A Software for Water Scarcity / Management of Water Resources. *Institution of Engineers (India), Jammu Local Centre, April 2007.*
- Paper presented at the National Conference on Next Generation Computing and Information Systems, *Model Institute of Engineering and Technology (MIET), Jammu, May 2007.*

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Course Instructor | **Thapar School of Liberal Arts & Sciences (TSLAS), TIET, Patiala** | *Semester VI, 2023*

Course: Organisational Change & Development | HRM specialisation course | Students: 6th Semester undergraduates, TSLAS

WORKSHOPS & TRAINING DELIVERED

Technical Workshop Instructor | **7 Base Repair Depot (BRD), Indian Air Force** | *2015–2018*

Workshop: HOBO Robotic Vehicle Training — EOD Lab, 7 BRD | Participants: Air warriors and officers from all units operating HOBO vehicles, including WAC squadrons

- Part of the EOD Lab team that revamped HOBO robotic vehicles used for Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD), replacing their transmitter and receiver modules
- Delivered hands-on training for operating units on the structural and functional changes in the revamped vehicles

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Head – Brand Strategy, Communications & Operations | **TIET, Patiala** | *May 2022 – Present*

Official designation: Head – Marketing & Admissions | Scope: Premier engineering & management institution | Reported to Vice Chancellor | Cross-functional leadership across brand, outreach, enrolment, international programmes & accreditation

- Architected institution-wide brand strategy and digital outreach; led TIET's positioning in national industry forums including FICCI
- Delivered the BSIS Impact Label (EFMD Global) — making TIET the first full university globally to receive the label; managed AACSB accreditation pipeline
- Led international academic partnerships across 7 countries: represented the institution at MARIHE Consortium meetings (Porto, Portugal; Finland) and managed the full international student lifecycle, from curriculum to country immersion
- Built the Japan partnership with JETRO and MMRI; led a delegation of 7 international students to Japan for a sustainability course and cultural immersion, opening bilateral exchange
- Built and scaled enrolment operations infrastructure: CRM systems, pan-India tele-calling, regional outreach offices (Dehradun & Amritsar)
- Managed national and international rankings strategy, delivering measurable improvement in institutional standing

Operations Manager – Global Consulting (Actuarial Valuations) | **Willis Towers Watson GDS Pvt. Ltd., Mumbai** | *July 2018 – January 2021*

Scope: Fortune 500 client portfolio | US & UK stakeholder management | Selected from 180 candidates at PRCs at IIM

- Built WTW's offshore actuarial pension valuation operations from zero, with operational frameworks, quality-control and performance systems; grew client portfolio 3X in the first year
- Consistently delivered high Voice of Business Partner scores from US and UK stakeholders
- Advised Fortune 500 clients on executive compensation, rewards strategy, and HR transformation
- Reduced team attrition from 28% to near zero through structured performance measurement, a Route to Competency model, and succession planning

Squadron Leader – Technical Officer (Air Defence & Missile Systems) | **Indian Air Force** | *July 2008 – July 2018*

Scope: Decade of commissioned service | Air Defence operations | Supply chain for two Surface-to-Air missile systems | Led ~500 personnel

- Engineered ₹32 Crore savings to the exchequer through indigenous fabrication; presented to President of India and Defence Minister on Air Force Day
- Recognised by Air HQ for recovery of combat-critical equipment; member of the IAF Innovation Display Team
- Directed supply chain management for two Surface-to-Air missile systems: procurement, indigenisation, and vendor coordination with Russian and Ukrainian associates
- As Senior Production Engineer at Base Repair Depot, managed the end-to-end production lifecycle for missile system overhauls, including turnaround time, throughput, and quality assurance
- Led Air Defence operations and strategic deployments, including military train movement for live missile firing on the eastern coast
- Commanded and trained air warriors; managed workshops, appraisals, promotions, and grievance handling

CERTIFICATIONS & RECOGNITION

- Commendation by AOC-in-Chief, Maintenance Command, IAF — indigenous fabrication of combat-critical defence equipment
- 1st in Order of Merit — BPKC, Air Force Technical College, Bangalore
- 1st in Course — Missiles Technical Training (TETRA Basic Course), TTI Vadodara, IAF (2010)
- Lean Six Sigma Green Belt — KPMG
- Aeronautical Quality Assurance Course (AQAC) — Military Institute of Technology (MILIT), Pune (2015)
- Certified QA Inspector — Aeronautical Equipment
- Certified Internal Auditor — ISO 9001:2015, BEQI
- Leading High Performing Teams — Willis Towers Watson
- ILM Operational Development Programme — OEE Consulting Limited
- ICC Member — POSH Trained | Workplace Grievance & Compliance

INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENTS

AOM Annual Conference (Boston 2023; Copenhagen 2025) · **Social Entrepreneurship Conference** (IMD Lausanne 2024) · **USASBE Doctoral Consortium** (2024) · **MaRIHE Consortium** (Porto 2025; Finland 2023) · **Babson Entrepreneurship Research Conference** (Wellesley, MA 2025) · **UAE** (Market outreach, 2024) · **Japan** (JETRO/MMRI; student delegation, 2024)

LANGUAGES

English · Hindi · Punjabi · Dogri · German (Basic)

INTERESTS

Meditation & Spiritual Wellbeing · Reading & Research · Networking & Mentoring · Writing (Poetry & Academic) · Walking in Solitude